

Customization & Memory

Back in Work With AI you met the context window: the working memory the model reads before it answers.

Two of its inputs don't come from what you type each time. They persist across chats, and they're yours to set up: what you tell the model about yourself, and what it remembers.

You set some. The model picks up the rest.

Two kinds of persistent context shape every answer, even before you type your prompt. One is what you tell the model. The other is what the model picks up from working with you.

CUSTOM INSTRUCTIONS YOU SET



Personalization

Tell it once. Applies to every chat.

EXAMPLES

"Call me David."

"Be direct."

"Explain things like I'm in high school."

Use it for: who you are and how you like to work.



Projects

Instructions and files scoped to one piece of work.

EXAMPLES

"AP Bio study guide and rubric."

"Source documents for an essay."

"Notes for one specific class."

Use it for: what you're working on right now.

WHAT THE MODEL PICKS UP



Memory

What the model picks up about you as you work with it. In Claude, ChatGPT, and Gemini, you can see and edit what's been saved in Settings.

EXAMPLES

"You prefer short answers."

"You're studying for the SAT."

"You struggle with cellular respiration."

Use it for: personal continuity across time.



Some apps keep memory you can't see or edit. Check your settings.

If two instructions ever conflict, the more specific one wins: what you set for a project overrides your general personalization while you're working inside that project.

A real example. My name is Nate, and I'm writing this course with my twin brother Luke and my dad. I'll show you my prompt, asked two ways. First without any setup, then with my setup loaded.

WITHOUT MY SETUP

● YOU

What should we cover next?

● AI

Happy to help. What course are you teaching, and what have you covered so far? Once I know the subject and audience, I can suggest what fits next.

WITH MY SETUP



Personalization

Set once, every chat

- I'm a high school junior.
- Be direct. Skip the warmup.
- Pick one recommendation and explain why, not three options.



Project: "Be Smarter Than the Tool"

This project only

- Course audience: high school students
- Tone: McDonald's-humor friendly, plain copy, no em-dashes
- Currently writing: Controls section
- Sections done: Intro, Foundations, Inside AI, AI Answers
- Co-authors: my twin brother Luke and my dad



Memory

Picked up over time

- Flags when explanations feel too academic
- Pushed back last week on a lesson that felt repetitive
- Prefers interactive activities over heavy reading
- Will be co-leading an AI Club at school next year with brother Luke

● YOU

What should we cover next?

● AI

Controls is wrapped, so Traps is next. Hallucination's the most important one. You flagged last time that lessons were getting heavy on reading, so open Hallucination with an interactive: paste a real-looking academic citation, ask ChatGPT if the paper exists, watch it invent details. One demo, one insight: confident ≠ correct. Want me to write a first draft?



Same prompt. Different setup. Completely different response.

Your turn. For each piece of information below, decide where it should live. Not everything belongs in persistent setup. Some things just need to live in this chat. Some shouldn't be saved at all.



Three things can go sideways. Bad personalization builds a smarter flattery trap.

Memory is a note, not a fact, so check what's saved and correct or delete what shouldn't follow you forward. And for sensitive or one-off questions, use a temporary chat, turn memory off, or just ask the app not to remember it.

TRY IT

AI can remember things about you, and where you save a detail decides where it follows you. Place each item where it should live: every chat, one project, or just this chat.